



SHELTERED: (Right) released terrorists Azhar, Zargar and Syed; the hijacked IC-814 at Kandahar

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Pakistan's continued harbouring of hijackers and fugitives wanted by India besides again broadcasting aggressive anti-India propaganda has increased tension between the two countries

■ By Saurabh Shukla

With the Indo-Pakistan peace process grinding to a halt following political instability in Pakistan, the incremental gains of the composite dialogue process, to discuss crossborder terrorism, Jammu and Kashmir and other issues, seem to be lost and the trust deficit is widening with Pakistan's vitriolic anti-India propaganda on the rise.

What has made reconciliation difficult is Pakistan's continued support to crossborder terror against India. Take the case of the hijack of IC-814 to Kandahar in December 1999. While the minor conspirators were sentenced to life imprisonment by an Indian court on February 5, New Delhi is upset that the main culprits are still at large in

Pakistan. Many others on India's list of 40 fugitives, including three terrorists of Jaish-e-Mohammed (Jem) Maulana Masood Azhar, Mushtaq Ahmed Zargar and Ahmed Umar Syed, who later killed American journalist Daniel Pearl, continue to be in Pakistan. But pleas for their extradition, despite Interpol red-corner notices, have been ignored by Islamabad, in clear violation of the Montreal and Hague conventions, besides the SAARC convention on suppression of terrorism.

Two months back, the heavily-guarded residence of Indian High Commissioner Satyabrata Pal was broken into by suspected operatives from Pakistani intelligence agency ISI while he was away in Karachi. Though none of the valuables were touched, what was earlier dubbed as a simple bur-

glary has turned out to be a well planned intelligence coup. South Block is worried that the Pakistani intelligence may have got its hands on a treasure trove of sensitive information contained in Pal's stolen laptop. This has led to fears that some key Indian assets may have been compromised. The high commissioner's residence in Islamabad's high security G-6 locality was also manned by Pakistani security guards. The fact that the intruders chose to take away only his briefcase and laptop made it look suspicious. Although both sides have maintained silence on the issue, the security breach has vitiated the atmosphere. South Block insiders say it appears that the break-in was pre-planned and the agency may have been tipped off that the envoy used his laptop for se-